‘extramarital love with a married woman was considered the highest experience of life’. The *Kamasutra*, despite a standard disclaimer to ‘never seduce other men’s wives’ and to guard one’s own wives, dedicates one of its seven sections to the artful seduction of other men’s wives, using a spectrum of tactics ranging from gentlemanly to thuggish. Desai cites sources to show that kings and feudal chiefs could ‘take liberty with wives of subordinates’. In a west Indian province, a man apparently presented his beautiful wives to the king and his ministers as a ‘love-gift’.[31]

Kings were often ‘described in eulogies and inscriptions as great lovers’. Vatsyayana mentions a kingdom in Gujarat where women apparently turned up at the royal harem on their own, singly or in groups, to volunteer their services to the king. Royal and aristocratic harems often had women from all over India and even Africa and Arabia. ‘Sanskrit poets and *Kamashastra* [“science of erotica”] writers take delight in describing the peculiarities of the amorous pleasures of women of different regions.’ Lonely women in the harem used sex toys, and in desperate times seduced guards, servants, artisans and men who were sneaked in disguised as women. Just south of Khajuravahaka, in Vidarbha, ‘women in the royal harem allowed beautiful village women to enter and stay with them for a fortnight or a month’. The princes of Vidarbha even ‘had access to the harems and mated with all wives of their father except their own mother’. In eastern India, Brahmins ‘obtained permission to enter the harem with the excuse of offering flowers’. In some cases, even the ‘wives of the king helped him in his affairs’. Aphrodisiacs and sex potions were much in demand.[32]

No wonder, adds Desai, ‘the art of this sensuous society was suffused with eroticism’. Erotica also appeared on secular objets d’art in their living spaces: on combs, toilet trays, paintings and furniture.[33] Literary poetic works from the second half of the first millennium also abound with sensual love play. Even the non-elites, who subscribed of the new Tantra-infused sects, likely had fewer hang-ups about sex and courtship when compared to their counterparts today. Desai writes that during certain revelries and festivals of fertility, amid wine, song and dance, a wider cross-section of people let their hair down and ignored many traditional restraints on sexual morality.[34] Married women on such occasions were said to pursue